

Iep Special Needs Parent Navigation — Action Checklist

PRINT THIS PAGE AND KEEP IT SOMEWHERE VISIBLE

KNOW YOUR LEGAL RIGHTS

- ☐ **Know Your Legal Rights:** Understand that IDEA grants you specific rights including FAPE, and the school has a legal obligation to provide everything written in your child's IEP document.
- ☐ **Know Your Legal Rights:** Remember the 60-day evaluation timeline starts when you provide written consent, and you can decline any requested extensions since this is federal law.
- ☐ **Know Your Legal Rights:** Request an independent evaluation at district expense if you disagree with the school's evaluation results, because evaluations must use multiple comprehensive measures.
- ☐ **Know Your Legal Rights:** Verify the IEP team includes all required members — you, at least one regular education teacher, one special education teacher, a district representative, and someone who can interpret evaluation results.

PREPARE BEFORE THE MEETING

- ☐ **Prepare Before the Meeting:** Email the IEP coordinator at least 5 business days before the meeting to request all documents including the draft IEP, evaluation reports, progress notes, and any correspondence.
- ☐ **Prepare Before the Meeting:** Review the evaluation report to confirm the evaluator used standardized instruments that are normed for your child's age and disability, because outdated or inappropriate tests can invalidate results.
- ☐ **Prepare Before the Meeting:** Look for discrepancies between your child's test scores and their actual classroom performance, because a good score doesn't mean they're functioning adequately in class.
- ☐ **Prepare Before the Meeting:** Identify any evaluator recommendations that didn't make it into the proposed IEP goals, because bringing these gaps to the meeting can help close service gaps.

DOCUMENT EVERYTHING

- ☐ **Document Everything:** Send all requests and correspondence via email because it creates a timestamp and a legal paper trail that protects you if disputes arise later.
 - ☐ **Document Everything:** Write and bring a parent statement to the meeting that describes your child's needs, your observations, and what services you believe they require.
 - ☐ **Document Everything:** Keep written records of every verbal and written request made to the school, including any refusals, because documentation significantly improves outcomes in disputes.
 - ☐ **Document Everything:** Note when team members are missing from meetings, because an IEP meeting without required members may be procedurally deficient under IDEA.
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Companion to the full guide in your Lemon Squeezy library — check off each item as you complete it.